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A Shared Interest in Creating Speculative Scenarios, NYC-based Artist Duo Tong Wu & Yuguang Zhang

BY EDITORIAL TEAM | MAY 21, 2024

Tong Wu & Yuguang Zhang are a new media artist duo raised on the Internet. They now co-exist with their digital doubles in Brooklyn, New York, and Chrome browser. As a duo, they started their collaboration to research the capabilities and societal influence of generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) at the end of 2021, reflecting the deepening involvement of AI as a social entity in cultural production.

Their joint artistic practice, which incorporates finely-tuned generative AI models, immersive installations, web-based interactions, set design, and workshops, explores the dynamic and profound connections we make with ubiquitous AI systems embedded around us, as well as the societal and cultural shifts that accompany these interactions. Wu & Zhang's collaborative work has been commissioned to exhibit at the :iiddr Gallery in Lower East Manhattan, New York, Code:ART Festival 2023 in Palo Alto, California, and the INDEX Biennale 2022 in Braga, Portugal. They also have been invited to teach courses introducing generative AI to artist and designer communities at Yale University, New York University, CultureHub Art Center in New York, and the School of Visual Arts.



Bureau of Cloud Management Concept Art, 1456px x 816px, generative print, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

Thank you for joining us, Tong Wu and Yuguang Zhang. We'd love to hear how the journey has been as a new media artist duo. Can you tell us a little about yourself?

Sure. This is Tong Wu and Yuguang Zhang. We don't have a collective name yet, but we've been collaborating as a new media artist duo since 2021. Before that, we each had our own individual practices and explored different media independently, including web art, 3D animations, installations, and performance. We always have a shared interest in creating speculative scenarios to explore and untangle the complicated yet dynamic relationship we as humans could develop with symbiotic intelligence, social entities, as well as cultural and social systems amidst rapid AI development, which eventually drives our collaborative work. Through forms including video installations, interactive digital systems and workshops, our current focus lies in exploring AI as an emerging social entity, particularly its implications for human identity and our emotional responses to it.



Bureau of Cloud Management Exhibition View @ City of Palo Alto, size variable, custom cloud generation & archiving pipeline, monitors, raspberry pi, portable screen, keyboard, mouse, NFC badge, digital prints, vinyl prints, BCM props, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

What brings you to art? What ideas are you exploring in your practice?

Tong: In the past, I explored the world as a photojournalist, creating short feature documentaries that delved into the life experiences of different communities and the social challenges they've been through. The experience sparked my curiosity about the broad concept of "systems," the intricate webs of power dynamics shaping human interactions within different structures. Recognizing the diverse avenues for storytelling, I embarked on a new media art exploration roughly six years ago, diving into the realm of digital art.

Yuguang: While exploring diverse avenues for self-expression wasn't the sole impetus for my artistic journey, it certainly played a significant role. After years of fulfilling, yet demanding corporate work, I found myself drawn to the opportunity to explore alternative ways for personal and creative fulfillment. This desire, coupled with my long-standing fascination with speculative topics, ultimately led me to the world of art. Artmaking provides me with the boundless potential to delve into uncharted territories, to explore the fringes of the possible, and to engage with speculative concepts, venturing beyond the confines of the immediate and tangible.

As mentioned earlier, our joint practice now explores the connections we make with the ubiquitous AI systems embedded around us. For example, the surprises and struggles we have when we fully / partially surrender our authorship to intelligent algorithms, and the cultural & ethical shifts that come along in our society when we're overwhelmed by such "creative" AIs.



Bureau of Cloud Management Cloud Observer WorkStation @ City of Palo Alto, size variable, custom cloud submitting portal, raspberry pi, portable screen, keyboard, mouse, BCM props, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

You've been very active during the past few years. What is the most exciting thing you've done or accomplished so far?

Thanks for the recognition! We would say the most exciting thing we've accomplished was that for the very first time we exhibited our collaborative work, "Bureau of Cloud Management(BCM)" as a duo. We created BCM as a fictional government bureau that manages the clouds passing through its jurisdiction – reflecting on our collective memories of cloud observation and imagining an alternative scenario of human-AI

relationships. We were fortunate to have two exhibition opportunities for this work in the fall of 2023, which allowed us to refine this work from its initial concept to an immersive, interactive installation in a gallery space. While still a work in progress, BCM is progressively approaching its envisioned form.



Bureau of Cloud Management Cloud Observer WorkStation @ iidrr Gallery New York, size variable, custom cloud submitting portal, raspberry pi, portable screen, keyboard, mouse, BCM props, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

How would you define “success” in art?

Success and art are two words that can be interpreted in many ways. Here are our thoughts on what makes a successful artwork:

Art is a language that speaks when words fall short. It captures the intangible pulse of the zeitgeist, the unspoken anxieties and unspoken desires that linger beneath the surface of our world. The most potent works resonate precisely because the artist has been acutely receptive to their surroundings, translating the ephemeral into a form we can grasp.

However, a successful artwork doesn't simply offer a reflection. It acts as a prism, refracting our understanding. It might manipulate familiar concepts in unsettling ways, or cast the seemingly insignificant in a revelatory light. A powerful artwork challenges our default modes of seeing, questioning what we take for granted. In doing so, it offers us a liberating glimpse beyond the confines of the everyday.



Bureau of Cloud Management Cloud Observer WorkStation @ iidrr Gallery New York, size variable, custom cloud generation & archiving pipeline, monitors, raspberry pi, digital prints, vinyl prints, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

What does “community” mean to you? How do you see yourself in a community?

We appreciate this question. This is a time when technology is rapidly advancing, yet often leaving creative communities feeling vulnerable and overwhelmed. Over the past two years, we have witnessed the rapid development of generative AI applications. This has been accompanied by widespread concerns that AI will replace or diminish human agency and creative abilities. We believe that now more than ever, creative communities need to rediscover the power of connection.

Beyond providing information, support, and inspiration, community is about fostering a shared identity. This unity empowers us to form a stronger collective voice, enabling us to shape the ethical and responsible use of emerging technologies like generative AI.

We always want to contribute to building stronger community connections. Since October 2022, we’ve been hosting workshops focused on generative AI for diverse creative communities – designers, writers, interactive media artists, and many more. Our goal is to bridge the gap between creators and the technology that’s rapidly reshaping their fields. Too often, artists are seen merely as “end users,” but we want to empower them to understand generative AI’s profound potential, and the potential pitfalls like bias and misuse. This knowledge gives artists greater agency, allowing them to make informed choices about whether and how to integrate these transformative tools into their practice. Meanwhile, as we conduct workshops with different

communities, we also feel the sparks of communication between different art practice areas. The live experience and expertise of other creative communities can often provide us with new perspectives and considerations on the intervention of AI in art creation. This is also what we feel is the biggest gain in community building.



Bureau of Cloud Management Machine Observer @ iidrr Gallery New York, 12" x 7" x 5", custom-tuned vision assistant model, ESP32, e-ink displays, pillow moss, custom glass enclosure, LED, custom electronics, 2023

Do you have any advice that you would offer to others?

Once the domain of specialized research, AI now permeates society, reshaping our world in profound ways. This technological revolution also offers artists unprecedented tools, making AI a potent new medium, a complex subject for exploration, or even a dynamic collaborator to work with. We encourage artists to consider engaging with this transformative moment. By understanding AI's capabilities, we can evolve our artistic expression and influence its trajectory for the common good. Furthermore, our work can play a vital role in shaping the ethical and creative applications of AI technology.



Bureau of Cloud Management Cloud Archives Monitor @ :iidrr Gallery New York, size variable, custom cloud generation & archiving pipeline, 55" monitor, 2023 © Tong Wu, Yuguang Zhang

text & photo courtesy of **Tong Wu & Yuguang Zhang**

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Li Tang Community is a New York-based, artist-run 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization dedicated to amplifying the creative voices of the worldwide Asian diaspora. Founded in April 2020, Li Tang Community aims to feature the works and talents of today's most innovative Asian practitioners working in the varied fields of art, design, and contemporary culture. [View all posts by Editorial Team](#)

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